

KEY FIGURE

NAPOLEON BONAPARTE

1769–1821

Born in Corsica, Napoleon was an artillery officer who became the most charismatic general in the French Revolutionary armies. In 1799, he seized power in a military coup, declaring himself Emperor in 1804. Defeated at Waterloo in 1815, he died a prisoner of the British.



▲ An aggressive risk-taker, Napoleon used cavalry and artillery as shock forces on the battlefield. He fought 50 battles, winning most of them.

► THE BATTLE OF AUSTERLITZ

The mounted Russian Imperial Guard, flourishing their sabres, clash with Napoleon's infantry, armed with musket and bayonet, at Austerlitz in 1805.

KEY EVENTS

1792–1815

■ **1792** The French Revolutionary Wars begin, with a declaration of war against Austria.

■ **1793–94** Lazare Carnot, war minister of the French Republic, orders mass conscription, raising an army of around one and a half million soldiers.

■ **1805–06** Victories over the Austrian and Russian armies at Austerlitz, and the Prussians at Jena-Auerstadt, establish the dominance of Napoleon's Grande Armée.

■ **1807** Prussia reforms its armed forces by mass conscription, ending corporal punishment, and adopting combined arms tactics.

■ **1812** Napoleon invades Russia with an army of half a million men; about one in five of these survive the army's retreat from Moscow.

■ **1815** Napoleon is defeated at Waterloo by a British army under the Duke of Wellington, and the Prussian army of Field Marshal Gebhard Leberecht von Blücher.

KEY DEVELOPMENT

ARMIES OF THE REVOLUTIONARY ERA

The French Revolution of 1789 ushered in a new era of mass citizen armies, with battles fought on an unprecedented scale. The military genius of French emperor Napoleon Bonaparte, meanwhile, whose empire grew out of the revolution, gave European warfare a fresh dynamism.

From 1792 to 1815, the French Revolutionary Wars and the Napoleonic Wars kept Europe in an almost continuous state of warfare. There were a number of technological innovations during this period, some of which had an impact on the battlefield. The Chappe telegraph system, introduced by the French, in 1792 allowed messages to be sent rapidly over long distances via a chain of visual semaphore signalling stations – an invention of great value for military commanders. Meanwhile in 1794, at the Battle of Fleurus, the French also experimented with the use of a manned balloon

for reconnaissance – the first ever instance of aerial warfare. Elsewhere, the British adopted shrapnel shells as anti-personnel munitions, and Congreve rockets as auxiliary artillery. However, the impact of these innovations was overshadowed by the changes that took place in military organization and tactics.

THE LEVÉE EN MASSE

In 1793, threatened with invasion by a coalition of hostile powers, the revolutionary French Republic issued a call for a *levée en masse* – the conscription

